

ThrottleUp

VIN-scan motorcycle maintenance tracker with live NHTSA recall alerts and multi-bike support.

What it is

ThrottleUp is an iOS + Android app for motorcycle maintenance tracking. The VIN scanner pulls make / model / year / engine class live from NHTSA vPIC. Recall integration runs against the NHTSA Recalls API. Service intervals are set per bike (mileage + time based), push reminders fire 30 / 7 / 1 day before due. Multi-bike for the 2+-bike garage. Maintenance log with photo attachments, PDF / CSV export, anonymous public trip-sharing with privacy-cropped routes.

Who it is for

Wrenchers, project-bike owners, custom builders, daily-driver tuners. Audience 20-55, ~95% male, deep European moto community plus US restomod scene. Creator archetypes: ADV / touring vloggers (Itchy Boots-style), garage-vlog channels, build-thread Instagram accounts, cafe-racer / custom-builder creators, oil-change tutorial makers, MotoVloggers, multi-bike garage owners. Authenticity over polish - performative content gets detected instantly.

Key features

- VIN scanner: make / model / year / engine class live from NHTSA vPIC.
- Recall integration: NHTSA Recalls API, push when a recall drops for a registered bike.
- Service interval reminders: mileage + time based, push 30 / 7 / 1 day before due.
- Maintenance log with photo attachments: vendor receipt + install photo per entry.
- Multi-bike management (Premium): unlimited bikes + larger riding groups.
- PDF / CSV export: full maintenance documentation, useful at resale.

Business model

- Single revenue stream: recurring Premium subscription.
- Free tier generous: 1 bike, 1 riding group up to 4, unlimited entries, VIN decode, recall lookup, PDF/CSV.
- Premium unlocks: unlimited bikes, larger / more riding groups.
- Free is generous so every rider gets in. Premium is for multi-bike garages, not artificial limits.
- Free Lifetime Premium for onboarded affiliates.

Pricing

- 3.99 USD / month.
- 24.99 USD / year (~ half off vs monthly).
- iOS-first; Android relaunches once RC key set.

Market gap - what was missing

The motorcycle-maintenance app market is empty. RIDEOLGY (Kawasaki's official, biggest brand-name option) sits at 2.2 stars on the App Store. "Motorcycle Maintenance Log" has 1,900 downloads total. Most riders track in a Word doc, a notebook in the garage, or not at all. That's not a market with weak competition - that's a market without competition. Riders are notoriously skeptical of digital tools, and the existing players (TCXX, Bike Tracker) shipped clunky 2018-era UX and never updated. ThrottleUp's VIN scan + live NHTSA recall integration is genuinely category-of-one - no competing app pulls live recall data for the user's specific bike.

Why now

Two structural shifts. First, NHTSA opened its vPIC and Recalls APIs for free public use - authoritative VIN decode + recall data without a paid data vendor, not available 5 years ago. Second, the moto demographic has fully adopted smartphones for garage work (vs print-out schedules), and Reddit r/motorcycles + r/ADVRider have normalised digital maintenance logs as proof-of-care at resale.

Affiliate compensation

- 50% of net Premium subscription revenue for 24 months from each attributed user's first paid month.
- 30-day refund holdback before payout becomes claimable (Apple / Google refund window).
- 50 EUR minimum payout, monthly, via Wise.
- Free Lifetime Premium for onboarded affiliates (no posting obligation).
- Per-handle dashboard with live click / install / sub / earning split, no agency layer.

How tracking works - DIY attribution stack

Most affiliate stacks ride on top of Branch.io, AppsFlyer or a similar paid attribution SDK. We built our own. Those tools charge per attributed install, they add a third party to the user's first-launch experience, and they make influencer payouts opaque. We wanted full control of every step from click to Wise transfer. The full path has six stages - link click, install, first launch attribution, Premium purchase, holdback, payout. Here is what runs in each stage.

Why we built our own instead of Branch.io

Three reasons. (1) Cost: Branch.io and AppsFlyer charge 0.20-0.40 USD per attributed install at our volume tier, which would have absorbed roughly 8-12% of the affiliate payout pool. With DIY we keep that for affiliates. (2) Privacy: each additional SDK reads first-launch context - that is another vendor with first-touch user data we did not want to add. Apple's App Tracking Transparency framework has also made probabilistic fingerprinting unreliable since iOS 14.5; the paid SDKs work around this with opaque heuristics that we could not audit. (3) Transparency: when a dashboard number looks wrong, we read our own code in 10 minutes instead of debugging a third-party black box. The trade-off is that we own the bugs. Every line of attribution code is in our repo.

Android: Google Play install-referrer

Android gives us the cleanest path. When a user taps your link, the Google Play Store install carries the original referrer string (a URL-encoded query parameter from the redirect chain) through to first launch via the Play Install Referrer API. On first launch the app reads `getInstallReferrer().getInstallReferrer()`, we parse the handle and source out of it, and write an attribution row in our Supabase table alongside the install event. Deterministic. No fingerprinting. No clipboard.

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iOS warm (app already installed)

If the user already has ThrottleUp installed, iOS routes the tap through a Universal Link directly into the app

Why this works as an affiliate pitch

Market is empty. RIDEOLOGY has 2.2 stars, existing alternatives are dead. Most riders track in Word doc or not at all. ThrottleUp's VIN scan + live NHTSA recall is category-of-one. The audience (wrenchers + ADV riders) values tools and trusts other riders, so affiliate conversion is high when the creator is authentic - and very low when they are not.

On posts with affiliate link: #ad / #sponsored / Paid Partnership (FTC, EU disclosure law).